

Long roots: on India and patriarchal biases

Entrenched patriarchal biases must be **erased** from society, government

If institutions are serious about **rooting out sexism**, they must **walk the talk**. Instead of **merely** celebrating the entry of more women in the workforce, they have to provide an enabling atmosphere for those **on the rolls**. In a judgment last week, the Supreme Court of India showed its **intent** by declaring that with more and more women joining judicial service, it was time for the judiciary to be more **cognisant** of their well-being at the workplace. **Reinstating** two women judicial officers of Madhya Pradesh who had been **sacked** for “**inefficiency**”, despite the fact that one of them had suffered a **miscarriage**, Justice B.V. Nagarathna said it was not enough to “find comfort **solely** in the growing number of female judicial officers if we are unable to secure for them a sensitive work environment.” The judgment **set aside** the **ouster** of two civil judges, Sarita Choudhary and Aditi Kumar Sharma, **terming** the **termination** orders “**punitive, arbitrary** and illegal”. **That** Justice Nagarathna, one of two women judges in the Court, which has a **sanctioned** strength of 34, had to **step in**, **is** an indication of the long and difficult fight for gender equality, and the need for change in mindsets and reform. In several past **verdicts** too, the Court had drawn attention to **gender stereotyping** and discrimination against women.

In her judgment, Justice Nagarathna **underscored** the importance of having more women in the judiciary, and this **holds true** of other branches of the government such as the **legislature** and the executive. Greater representation of women will ensure better understanding of their needs and **lead to** better policies. **The freedom** from discrimination or equal protection of the laws during pregnancy and **maternity** are precious rights for the women **workforce**, she noted. Just as **motherhood** brings joy, a miscarriage has a deep psychological, physical and mental impact on women, and the **onus** is on policymakers to be aware of this and act accordingly. While gender cannot be an excuse for poor performance, it is **incredible** that the Court had to intervene to **call out** a wrong on a basic issue such as maternal rights. In doing so, the Court has also, yet again, reminded not only those in power but also the larger society, that age-old, entrenched patriarchal systems have no place in a country **aspiring** to emerge as a developed economy. If women are not provided a larger role in decision-making, their concerns will remain invisible to policy. To achieve that goal, education has to be accessible to girls in a non-discriminatory manner. At work, they must be assured of a safe and healthy environment as a basic right and guarantee.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where ‘red’ denotes ‘subject’ and ‘blue’ denotes ‘verb’.

Vocabulary

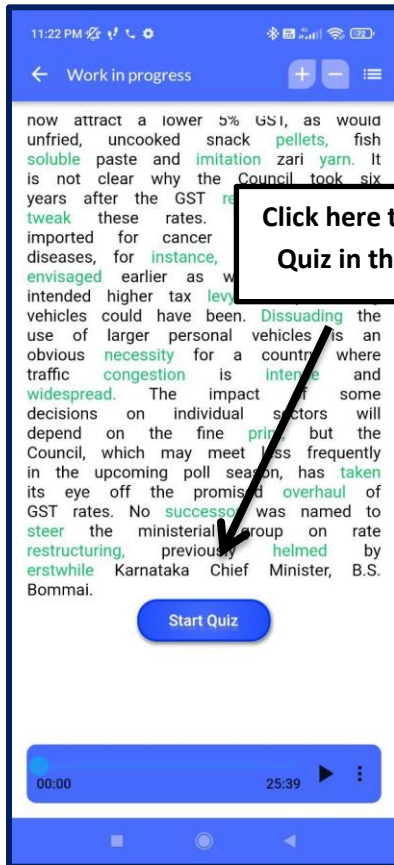
1. **Patriarchal** (adjective) – Male-dominated, Traditional, Authoritarian, Conservative, Hierarchical पितृसत्तात्मक
2. **Bias** (noun) – Prejudice, Partiality, Discrimination, Inclination, Favoritism पक्षपात
3. **Entrenched** (adjective) – Deep-rooted, Firm, Established, Ingrained, Fixed गहराई से जमा हुआ
4. **Erase** (verb) – Remove, Eliminate, Wipe out, Obliterate, Delete हटाना
5. **Root out** (phrasal verb) – Eliminate, Eradicate, Remove, Uproot, Destroy जड़ से खत्म करना
6. **Sexism** (noun) – Gender bias, Discrimination, Prejudice, Chauvinism, Inequality लैंगिक भेदभाव
7. **Walk the talk** (phrase) – Act on words, Practice what you preach, Follow through, Deliver, Implement जो कहते हैं, वही करते हैं
8. **Merely** (adverb) – Only, Simply, Just, Solely, Purely केवल
9. **On the rolls** (phrase) – Employed, Registered, Listed, Enrolled, Included नियुक्त
10. **Intent** (noun) – Aim, Purpose, Goal, Objective, Intention इरादा
11. **Cognisant** (adjective) – Aware, Conscious, Mindful, Informed, Knowledgeable जागरूक
12. **Reinstate** (verb) – Restore, Reappoint, Rehabilitate, Return, Bring back बहाल करना
13. **Sack** (verb) – Dismiss, Fire, Terminate, Remove, Expel नौकरी से निकालना
14. **Inefficiency** (noun) – Incompetence, Ineffectiveness, Negligence, Failure, Slackness अक्षमता
15. **Miscarriage** (noun) – Pregnancy loss, Abortion, Stillbirth, Spontaneous abortion, Fetal loss गर्भपात
16. **Solely** (adverb) – Only, Exclusively, Purely, Merely, Entirely केवल
17. **Set aside** (phrasal verb) – Overturn, Cancel, Annul, Reverse, Quash रद्द करना
18. **Ouster** (noun) – Removal, Expulsion, Ejection, Dismissal, Eviction बर्खास्तगी
19. **Term** (verb) – Call, Label, Name, Designate, Describe कहना
20. **Termination** (noun) – End, Conclusion, Closure, Dismissal, Cancellation समाप्ति
21. **Punitive** (adjective) – Penal, Disciplinary, Retributive, Corrective, Punishing दंडात्मक

22. **Arbitrary** (adjective) – Random, Unreasonable, Unjust, Whimsical, Discretionary मनमाना
23. **Sanctioned** (adjective) – Approved, Authorized, Permitted, Endorsed, Legalized मंजूर
24. **Step in** (phrasal verb) – Intervene, Interfere, Mediate, Intercede, Act हस्तक्षेप करना
25. **Verdict** (noun) – Judgment, Decision, Ruling, Finding, Conclusion फैसला
26. **Gender stereotyping** (noun) – Gender bias, Prejudice, Discrimination, Labeling, Categorization लैंगिक रूढ़िवादिता
27. **Underscore** (verb) – Emphasize, Highlight, Stress, Accentuate, Reinforce जोर देना
28. **Hold true** (phrase) – Apply, Be valid, Remain relevant, Stand, Be applicable सही होना
29. **Legislature** (noun) – Parliament, Assembly, Council, Lawmaking body, Government विधानमंडल
30. **Lead** (to) (verb) – Cause, Result in, Bring about, Produce, Trigger वजह बनना
31. **Maternity** (noun) – Motherhood, Pregnancy, Childbirth, Parenthood, Gestation मातृत्व
32. **Workforce** (noun) – Employees, Staff, Labor, Personnel, Workers कार्यबल
33. **Motherhood** (noun) – Parenthood, Maternity, Child-rearing, Parenting, Family मातृत्व
34. **Onus** (noun) – Responsibility, Burden, Duty, Obligation, Liability जिम्मेदारी
35. **Incredible** (adjective) – Unbelievable, Amazing, Astonishing, Remarkable, Unreal अविश्वसनीय
36. **Call out** (phrasal verb) – Expose, Highlight, Point out, Challenge, Denounce जाहिर करना
37. **Aspire** (to) (verb) – Aim, Strive, Seek, Desire, Hope आकांक्षा करना

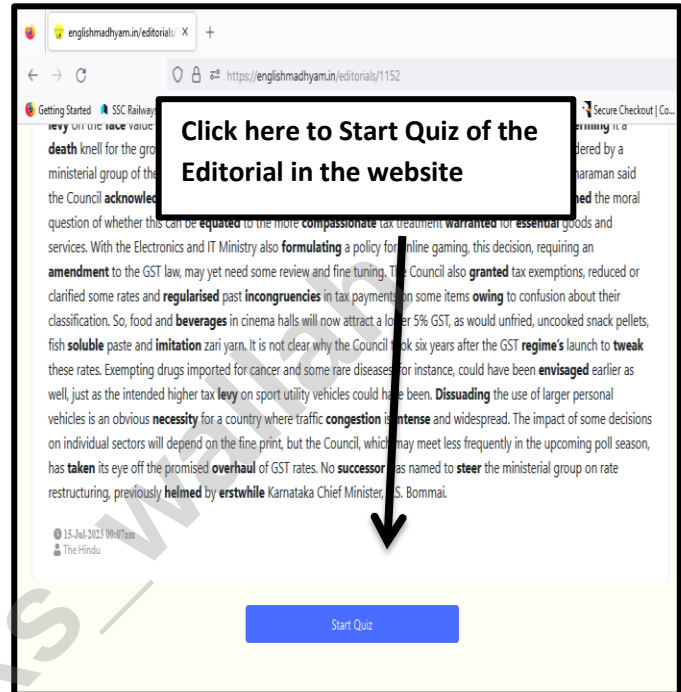
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Core Issue:** The editorial spotlights entrenched patriarchal biases in India, emphasizing the urgent need to erase them from society and government institutions.
2. **Supreme Court Intervention:** The Supreme Court recently underscored the importance of ensuring women's well-being in the judiciary, indicating that having more women in the system alone is insufficient without sensitivity to their needs.
3. **Case of Two Women Judges:** The Court reinstated two Madhya Pradesh judicial officers, pointing out their termination was "punitive, arbitrary and illegal," particularly noting one officer's miscarriage during her tenure.
4. **Justice Nagarathna's Observations:** She highlighted that numbers (of women in the judiciary) are meaningless unless the workplace environment is cognizant of women's unique challenges, like pregnancy and miscarriage.
5. **Importance of Maternal Rights:** The judgment reaffirmed that legal and institutional frameworks must safeguard rights during pregnancy and maternity, as these are fundamental for working women.
6. **Broader Gender Discrimination:** The Court's stance continues its trend of drawing attention to gender stereotyping and discrimination, stressing the need for equality and fairness.
7. **Need for More Women in Leadership:** Justice Nagarathna stressed increased representation of women across the government—legislature, executive, and judiciary—for a nuanced understanding of women's issues.
8. **Connection to Policy:** More women in decision-making roles can lead to better policies that address women's concerns more effectively.
9. **Human Impact of Miscarriage:** The editorial underlines that a miscarriage is not just a medical issue but has deep psychological, physical, and emotional effects on women.
10. **Institutions Must 'Walk the Talk':** Merely celebrating higher female workforce participation is not enough; workplaces need to genuinely support women's rights and accommodate their specific needs.
11. **Educational Access:** The piece stresses that education for girls, provided on an equal and non-discriminatory basis, is a fundamental step in challenging patriarchal structures.
12. **Safe Working Environments:** Beyond fair policies, a safe and healthy work environment is a non-negotiable requirement for women to thrive professionally.
13. **Patriarchal Systems Under Scrutiny:** The judgment exemplifies how entrenched biases manifest in punitive actions against women, necessitating continued efforts to dismantle these biases.
14. **Path to Development:** The editorial ties women's empowerment to India's broader goal of becoming a developed economy; without gender equality, true progress remains elusive.
15. **Long-Term Reform:** Ultimately, the piece calls for sustained institutional and societal reforms, ensuring equality is upheld in practice, not just in principle.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



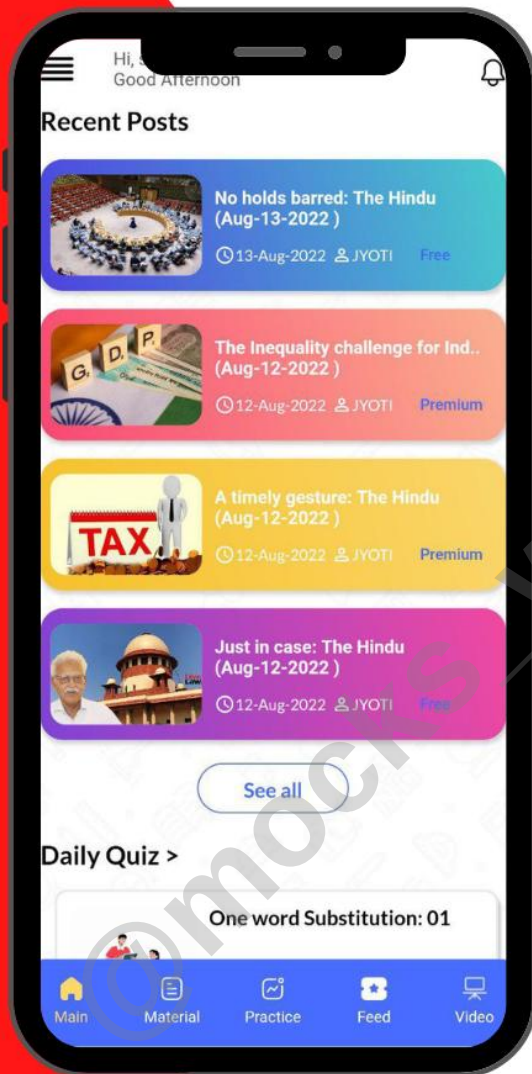
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